

Role of Entrepreneurial Education in Motivating Students to Take Entrepreneurship as a Career

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Abstract

Entrepreneurial education serves as a transformative force, shifting the focus from being mere job-seekers to becoming job creators. It nurtures entrepreneurial spirit and mindset by instilling in students the values of creativity, risk-taking, and perseverance. Through experiential learning, students are encouraged to explore their interests and ideas, guiding them toward innovation and problem-solving. By fostering an environment that encourages critical thinking and creativity, entrepreneurial education empowers students to break free from the traditional molds and think outside the box. One of the key advantages of entrepreneurial education lies in its ability to bridge the gap between theory and practice. The chapter focuses on explaining the role of Entrepreneurial education and acting as a forum for students to connect with industry experts, successful entrepreneurs, and like-minded individuals. The chapter further stresses the factors influencing entrepreneurship as a career choice including managers and policymakers creating conditions for students to choose entrepreneurship, including incorporating entrepreneurship in higher education curriculums, instilling higher entrepreneurship motivation in graduates, and addressing perceived barriers. Notably, entrepreneurial education sparks innovation and encourages students to identify and pursue new opportunities, however, the chances of being a successful entrepreneur afterward are still unknown and an open area to explore.

Key Points

A short bulleted list of key points or objectives for the chapter

- Entrepreneurial education serves as a powerful motivator, inspiring students to embrace entrepreneurship as a career path.
- By equipping students with the necessary knowledge, skills, and mindset, Entrepreneurial education empowers students to navigate the complex world of business with confidence and seize opportunities.
- Entrepreneurial education should not be seen as a ticket to success, but rather as an aid in understanding different dimensions of entrepreneurship.

Introduction

Entrepreneurial education plays a crucial role in inspiring and motivating students to pursue entrepreneurship as a career path (Barba-Sánchez and Atienza-Sahuquillo, 2018). With the growing popularity of startups and the recognition of entrepreneurs as key drivers of economic growth, it becomes imperative to equip students with the necessary knowledge, skills, and mindset to become successful entrepreneurs. This chapter explores the significance of entrepreneurial education in motivating students to embark on the entrepreneurial journey. It discusses various ways educational institutions can foster an entrepreneurial mindset among students. Entrepreneurship education provides students with the essential tools and knowledge required to identify and seize business opportunities (Zhang *et al.*, 2014). By learning about various aspects of entrepreneurship such as business planning, market analysis, and financial management, students are empowered to transform their creative ideas into viable business ventures (Baber *et al.*, 2023). Moreover, entrepreneurship education helps students develop a range of transferable skills such as critical thinking, problem-solving, and effective communication, which are invaluable in any career path they choose. One of the primary

objectives of entrepreneurial education is to foster creativity and innovation among students. It encourages them to think outside the box, challenge the status quo, and come up with unique solutions to problems. By exposing students to real-world business challenges and providing them with entrepreneurial frameworks, educational institutions can cultivate an environment where innovation thrives. This not only prepares students for the uncertainties of the future workforce but also instills an entrepreneurial mindset that encourages them to take calculated risks and seize opportunities (Cassol *et al.*, 2022).

Entrepreneurship is not an easy path. It requires individuals to step out of their comfort zones, embrace failure as a learning opportunity, and persevere despite adversity. Entrepreneurial education plays a pivotal role in building confidence and resilience among students by teaching them to navigate challenges and setbacks (Sølesvik *et al.*, 2014). By providing students with mentorship, experiential learning opportunities, and exposure to successful entrepreneurs, educational institutions can help students develop the self-belief and determination necessary to tackle the obstacles they will inevitably encounter on their entrepreneurial journeys.

The purpose of this chapter is to delve into the crucial role that entrepreneurial education plays in motivating students to pursue entrepreneurship as a viable and rewarding career option. Understanding the antecedents that lead students to choose entrepreneurship as a career is also essential in developing effective educational programs. Factors such as personal background, previous entrepreneurial exposure, and social support influence the inclination toward entrepreneurship among students. Through targeted educational interventions, we can address these antecedents and foster entrepreneurial aspirations. Moreover, entrepreneurial education not only shapes the decision to embark on an entrepreneurial journey but also contributes significantly to entrepreneurial success. By providing students with a comprehensive understanding of key entrepreneurial concepts, strategies, and practical tools, they are better prepared to navigate the challenges and opportunities that arise in the entrepreneurial landscape. Ultimately, the goal is to cultivate an entrepreneurial mindset and empower students to pursue their entrepreneurial aspirations with confidence, thereby fostering future entrepreneurs who can drive economic growth and societal transformation.

Entrepreneurship as a Career

Entrepreneurship as a career choice is a difficult decision to make for young people, especially due to the higher risks involved in such an activity and the particular abilities required. This choice has been widely discussed in the specialized literature and numerous factors have been found to influence such a choice. Managers and policymakers are credited with the capacity to create the conditions for nurturing students to choose entrepreneurship as a career. One of these conditions is to include the study of entrepreneurship in the curriculum of all study programs in higher education, irrespective of the main field of study (Netshiliganedza *et al.*, 2022). Besides capabilities, universities may also be able to instill higher entrepreneurship motivation in their graduates (Tomy and Pardede, 2020). Skills and skill awareness (Tomy and Pardede, 2020), self-efficacy, awareness (Aggarwal and Shrivastava, 2021), entrepreneurial resources, and entrepreneurial support networks are prerequisites to pursue entrepreneurship (Tomy and Pardede, 2020).

Other factors that influence people to become entrepreneurs include family support, school environment, resilience (Pérez-López *et al.*, 2016), and the existence of role models (BarNir *et al.*, 2011). An equally important factor in becoming an entrepreneur is played by the self-evaluation of perceived barriers to such a career (Sharma and Madan, 2013). In some countries, a barrier in the way of entrepreneurship is the way entrepreneurs are valued or their social status (Kalden *et al.*, 2017).

From a personal standpoint, certain authors argue that it is more likely that those with higher emotional intelligence, particularly the ones who can better regulate emotions, will choose to be entrepreneurs (Kanonuhwa *et al.*, 2018). Also, students with proactive personalities are more likely to become entrepreneurs, as results from a study conducted by Mustafa *et al.* (2023). The ability to seize or identify opportunities may also explain this career choice (Asante and Affum-Osei, 2019).

From a macroeconomic perspective, Solomon *et al.* (2021) find that developing countries that have high levels of social spending generate higher opportunity costs for entrepreneurship. In other words, entrepreneurial initiatives are less attractive to citizens who may instead choose paid jobs. On the other hand, highly regulated credit markets work as a deterrent to entrepreneurial intention, due to lower access to capital, whereas stricter labor regulations lead to more entrepreneurial activity. This is because there is less job availability in such economies, and people tend to substitute paid jobs with entrepreneurship (Ghosh, 2017). Therefore, public policy regarding public spending and credit and labor markets largely influence entrepreneurship take-up and start-up creation rates.

Certain categories of people may feel it more difficult to start a business. In this respect, the extant literature presents the case of temporary workers and women. Temporary workers often believe they are not equipped with the competences that are required to be an entrepreneur (Costa *et al.*, 2016), therefore this would be another category that is less prone to pursue entrepreneurship in their professional life. Thébaud (2010) discusses the gender gap in entrepreneurship as a structural disadvantage in females to pursue an entrepreneurship career due to insufficient resource acquisition for this purpose. The author stresses that cultural gender bias is one of the root causes of women's underrepresentation in entrepreneurship, and it leads to women's self-assessment of entrepreneurial ability being low. Particularly low levels of entrepreneurship as a career choice among females have been found in the Gulf Cooperation Council countries. The main barriers faced by women in turning higher education into higher equality in the labor market are identified: difficulty in accessing capital, lack of supportive regulatory environment and lack of pre-venture assistance, dual roles and responsibilities regarding family and professional life, social attitudes and traditions, lack of family support, limited social networks and ties, gender bias, lack of managerial and IT skills, risk aversion, opportunity identification

process, motivation, and personality barriers, preference for employment in the public sector (Faisal *et al.*, 2017). Social segregation and gender roles have a strong impact on women's decision to become entrepreneurs in other socially constrained cultures, as is the one in Pakistan (Hafeez *et al.*, 2021). In other environments, women claim they need more family support services, which would allow them to take up entrepreneurial projects and lift their worries off their families (Dewitt *et al.*, 2023).

Antecedents of Entrepreneurship as a Career Among Students

Entrepreneurship, established as a distinct domain of scholarly inquiry, has achieved considerable distinction over the past decade. It is now recognized as a crucial catalyst for economic and regional advancement (Nowiński and Haddoud, 2019) and as an integral component of governmental policy development and economic dynamism (Hoang *et al.*, 2020). Nonetheless, formulating a precise definition of entrepreneurship presents a complex challenge: a constricted definition might exclude essential dimensions such as entrepreneurship within marginalized contexts, whereas an excessively expansive definition risks conflating with the domain of entrepreneurship education, thereby attenuating the distinct identity of entrepreneurship as an academic discipline (Stevenson and Jarillo, 2007). From Schumpeter's (1982) perspective of igniting new markets and promoting disruptive innovations to the recognition and exploitation of opportunities, the implementation of strategic thinking, effective resource allocation, and the establishment of networks throughout the entrepreneurial endeavor (Parker, 2018), entrepreneurship has witnessed substantial evolution.

Entrepreneurship has been firmly established as an unequivocal catalyst for economic growth, notably distinguished by its inherent ability to create employment opportunities (Kuratko *et al.*, 2005). Countries, particularly those in the developing spectrum, are encouraged to cultivate and provide a conducive environment for the emergence of entrepreneurial endeavors (Iwu, 2018). Numerous academics posit that education serves as a fundamental tool to ignite this entrepreneurial spirit (Iwu *et al.*, 2016; Potishuk and Kratzer, 2017; Duval-Couetil and Long, 2014). Studies have demonstrated that education, especially focused on entrepreneurial training, markedly enhances the prospects of success in this realm, thereby affirming a beneficial correlation between entrepreneurial education and economic advancement (Pittaway and Cope, 2007; Cheung, 2008). Acknowledging that a nation's future prosperity is largely contingent upon its youth (Morris *et al.*, 2017; Nowiński *et al.*, 2019; Iwu, 2018), their attitudes and inclinations toward pursuing entrepreneurship as a career path emerge as pivotal considerations. Consequently, educational frameworks and public policies must be strategically aligned to nurture and amplify this mindset, ensuring the cultivation of a forthcoming generation of entrepreneurs poised to contribute to the vitality and sustainability of the global economy.

In exploring the students' perception of entrepreneurship as a viable career path, research suggests that their social networks and academic settings significantly shape their views and valuation of entrepreneurship as a profession (Nchimbi, 2002; Bosma *et al.*, 2012). Additional elements influencing their perception encompass the accessibility of business opportunities, entrepreneurial management competencies, the level of risk involved, and the fear of failure in initiating and managing a venture (Iwu *et al.*, 2016). This indicates that students' perspectives on entrepreneurship are influenced not only by personal viewpoints but also by a combination of internal and external factors that can either stimulate or hinder their active engagement in entrepreneurial activities. Consequently, it is critical to identify and address these variables to effectively foster and augment entrepreneurial spirit among aspiring professionals.

The consensus is clear that the reservoir of entrepreneurial knowledge is an essential asset within the corporate milieu (Barney, 1991). This particular dimension of human capital profoundly alters an individual's competence self-assessment across various business domains, leading to a more nuanced and accurate comprehension of entrepreneurial dynamics (Ajzen, 2002). Within this context, entrepreneurial knowledge, serving as a foundational institutional component, diverges into two primary categories: (1) tacit knowledge and (2) explicit knowledge. Tacit knowledge, which is subjective and inherent, necessitates internalization and is acquired over time through an individual's cognitive processes (Daft and Lengel, 1986). Conversely, explicit knowledge is objective and transferable, efficiently communicated through intensive entrepreneurship programs or specialized management workshops.

Entrepreneurial Education as a Driving Force

A plethora of studies affirm that entrepreneurial education exerts a substantial impact on entrepreneurial development. Díaz-Casero *et al.* (2012) contend that such education influences entrepreneurship by integrating cultural and social norms and values, which are defined as the expected thought patterns and behaviors within a particular group sharing similar cultures and networks (Morris *et al.*, 2017). Similarly, Zlatković (2018) concurs, elucidating that aligning these cultural and social norms with entrepreneurial principles modifies individuals' motivation and skills, thereby affecting their entrepreneurial decisions. Conversely, Kuratko *et al.* (2005) posits that education not only fosters but also refines entrepreneurial traits such as opportunity identification and exploitation, risk-taking in challenging situations, and the determination to actualize theoretical plans. Echoing this, Morris *et al.* (2013) assert that entrepreneurial education is a potent mechanism for enhancing fundamental entrepreneurial skills like optimism, passion, strategic behavior, and resource leveraging. Collectively, these studies underscore the vital role of integrating entrepreneurship education into training systems to cultivate and bolster entrepreneurial skills and spirit.

In the realm of student education, entrepreneurship is perceived as a process wherein an entrepreneurial opportunity is identified or created through the acquisition of entrepreneurial knowledge, aspiring to generate employment and positively impact the market and society. With this conception, Jones and English (2004) describe entrepreneurial education as a process aimed at equipping individuals with the necessary skills and capabilities to identify commercially viable opportunities and the knowledge, insight, and self-efficacy to act upon them. The consensus among various discussions is that entrepreneurial education facilitates entrepreneurship (Bakar *et al.*, 2015; Matlay, 2006), with Bakar *et al.* (2015) observing that it elevates a person's entrepreneurial level, enhancing decision-making skills and entrepreneurial capabilities, independent of their innate personality traits. Furthermore, Jones and Iredale (2010) advocate that the primary objective of entrepreneurial education should be to foster efficient and sustainable entrepreneurship, necessitating a structured approach that provides robust conceptual and theoretical frameworks for academics and practitioners (Hynes, 1996). A wealth of research firmly establishes a significant interplay between entrepreneurial education and the formation of entrepreneurial firms (Raposo and Paço, 2011). Emphasizing the importance of early entrepreneurial education, several studies suggest it builds a solid foundation for aspiring entrepreneurs (Marques *et al.*, 2012; Paco *et al.*, 2011; Cheng *et al.*, 2009).

Entrepreneurial Education programs are increasingly pivotal in acquainting students with the intricacies and challenges of entrepreneurship. Extensive investigations into the motivators for becoming an entrepreneur consider various situations and circumstances that may influence this decision. Personal traits like self-efficacy, the need for achievement, and the fear of failure are identified as significant indicators of entrepreneurial intentions (Louw *et al.*, 2003), while external conditions such as family context, geographic location, migration, and gender are explored as potential facilitators or barriers (Basu, 2004; Jennings and McDougald, 2007). Notably, individuals from entrepreneurial families often exhibit a stronger propensity towards entrepreneurship compared to those without such backgrounds (Henry *et al.*, 2005), with peer influence also playing a role in shaping entrepreneurial intentions, moderated by the individual's level of individualism (Falck *et al.*, 2012). Interestingly, Zellweger *et al.* (2011) found that students from entrepreneurial families, despite potential pessimism about their entrepreneurial future, often possess high self-efficacy for such endeavors.

Entrepreneurial initiative is not a random occurrence but rather a deliberate and considered decision (Krueger, 2007a,b). Thus, entrepreneurial intentions are recognized as the most potent and direct predictor of future entrepreneurial activities, consolidating as a central variable extensively examined in contemporary entrepreneurial research (Kautonen *et al.*, 2015; Kautonen *et al.*, 2013; Lee *et al.*, 2011). Ultimately, perception is paramount in entrepreneurship, as a positive perspective potentially stimulates the inclination to engage in entrepreneurship. For instance, believing in one's ability to surmount inherent entrepreneurial challenges is indicative of an optimistic entrepreneurial outlook (Palich and Bagby, 1995; Moy *et al.*, 2003). However, this favorable mindset can be shaped or even distorted by both endogenous and exogenous factors. Endogenous factors, over which individuals have some degree of control, include aspects like personality and character. Conversely, exogenous factors, generally beyond personal influence, encompass external variables such as government policies, tax burdens, and national economic conditions (Edelman, Yli-Renko, 2010). These external components can significantly influence the perception and feasibility of entrepreneurial ventures. Understanding and nurturing a positive and realistic perception of entrepreneurship is essential to fostering and developing entrepreneurial potential in individuals and society at large.

Entrepreneurial Education and Entrepreneurial Success

Dickson *et al.* (2008) study based on research conducted in multiple countries, there is a general agreement among scholars that education has a significant and positive impact on entrepreneurial performance. However, the findings regarding the association between general education and the likelihood of becoming a successful entrepreneur are inconclusive. This review suggests several potential reasons for these ambiguous results, both in terms of theory and methodology. One crucial point highlighted in this review is the lack of consensus on how to define entrepreneurial education and what should be considered appropriate and measurable outcomes for such education. Existing research, although in its early stages, does provide some indications of the relationship between entrepreneurial education and subsequent entrepreneurial selection and success. These promising findings offer researchers valuable opportunities for further investigation in this important field of study.

Similarly, Aronsson (2004) interviewed David Birch who explained it by considering any company – does it always enjoy tranquility? Highly unlikely! An entrepreneur must possess the ability to tackle risks, challenges, and anxieties. How often does the entrepreneur find themselves awakening in the middle of the night, pondering over sources of funds for next week's payroll or crucial negotiations with key customers? Coping with consistent terror is not a skill possessed by many, I dare say. The approach an entrepreneur adopts to confront such terror is what ultimately determines their success. Thus, can someone be trained to confront perpetual terror and learn the requisite steps? Regrettably, he believes otherwise. Therefore, education on entrepreneurship cannot be seen as a ticket to be successful entrepreneurship, it can only aid in understanding by delving into different dimensions of entrepreneurship, including business planning, market analysis, and financial management, students gain the skills and knowledge to successfully convert their innovative ideas into business ventures.

Students often find inspiration in the success stories of entrepreneurs who have made a significant impact in their respective fields (Rae, 2004). Entrepreneurial education leverages the power of role models by showcasing successful entrepreneurs who have overcome challenges and achieved their goals. By sharing these stories and providing students with access to role models through guest lectures, workshops, and networking events, educational institutions can inspire and motivate students to believe in their potential as future entrepreneurs.

Entrepreneurial education goes beyond teaching practical skills; it also cultivates the entrepreneurial mindset. This mindset encompasses traits such as resilience, adaptability, creativity, and a willingness to take calculated risks. Through specialized courses and programs, aspiring entrepreneurs are exposed to real-world scenarios, case studies, and mentorship opportunities that help shape their entrepreneurial mindset. By instilling a growth mindset and providing a supportive environment, entrepreneurial education plays a vital role in nurturing the qualities necessary for success.

> Mentorship is another critical component of entrepreneurial education that significantly contributes to entrepreneurial success. A mentor provides guidance, wisdom, and practical advice based on their own experiences and expertise. Having a mentor allows entrepreneurs to benefit from the lessons learned by others, avoid pitfalls, and gain valuable insights. By establishing a relationship with a seasoned entrepreneur, aspiring business owners can tap into a wealth of knowledge and expertise that can accelerate their journeys toward success.

Networking plays a pivotal role in the entrepreneurial world, and entrepreneurial education provides an exceptional avenue for connecting with like-minded individuals. By participating in workshops, seminars, and entrepreneurial programs, aspiring entrepreneurs have the opportunity to build valuable relationships, collaborate with others, and tap into a network of resources and support. The connections made through entrepreneurial education can open doors to partnerships, funding opportunities, and mentorship, further empowering entrepreneurs on their path to success.

Effective entrepreneurial education thrives on a multi-faceted approach, combining both formal and informal methods of learning. Formal education, such as degree programs or specialized courses, provides a systematic and structured approach to acquiring knowledge and skills. On the other hand, informal education encompasses experiential learning, self-study, and hands-on involvement in entrepreneurial activities. By embracing both formal and informal methods, aspiring and seasoned entrepreneurs can gain a holistic understanding of the intricacies of the business world and develop the versatile skill set needed for success.

Conclusion

Entrepreneurial education among students may at first sight seem to be a very narrow area of concern in the realm of education and that is regarding only a small share of the population of a country. Nonetheless, it has far larger implications than education or the subjects of education. Entrepreneurship education generates positive externalities first of all by creating a culture of entrepreneurship in society. We have shown earlier how this type of education leads to job creation and that it leads to development and advancement in emerging and developed economies alike. Start-up creation positively influences job creation, which in turn influences the standard of living of the population - more people work and more incomes are earned. In addition, a higher level of production and more jobs mean a higher gross domestic product, which translates into economic growth. Education, in general, is one of the pillars of development, and quality education is one of the sustainable development goals (SDG4). Shortly, it has far-reaching implications for any country and sets the basis for long-term growth.

From a micro perspective, entrepreneurial education also fosters students to take more risks and innovate products, services, technologies, etc. In the absence of such an entrepreneurial spirit, markets and countries would be less competitive, and buyers would not benefit from the best solutions to their needs. From the perspective of Adam Smith, it is by pursuing the self-interest of entrepreneurs, by taking informed risks to produce, that resources are best allocated in the economy, and that the overall surplus of the society is maximized. Education particularly entrepreneurial education provides both the skills required to run a business successfully but also instills in students the courage to create and launch state-of-the-art products, to overcome barriers, and to explore and seize all market opportunities.

The setting of entrepreneurship education should not be confined to formal education, but it should be present in all forms and places so that the labor market and the whole economy benefit from better prepared and more entrepreneurs that are willing and able to operate in continuously changing environments. The survival rates and longevity of start-up companies under all types of pressures, challenges, and dynamics are a test of how good entrepreneurship education is. The resilience and adaptability of businesses are the cornerstone for further growth and development and the best way to preserve well-being among the population.

Considering all of the above, short-run and long-run economic goals can be reached if investment in education is a priority and entrepreneurship education represents a mandatory subject for all students, irrespective of the field they are training for. Also, conditions should be created so that this type of education is carried on throughout entrepreneurs' careers and it should become a life-long learning must.

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